> My previous faith and convictions underwent a remarkable modification. The romance of violent methods alone, which was so prominent amongst our predecessors, was replaced by serious ideas. No more mysticism, no more blind faith. Realism became our cult. *Use of force justifiable when resorted to as matter of terrible necessity, and non-violence as policy indispensable for all mass movements.* So much about methods. The most important thing was the clear conception of ideal for which we were to fight.[15]

Yet, more remarkable than this is how Bhagat Singh kept up with his reading even in the face of impending death. This is so surreal as to be unreal. And yet, it is well documented. When Pran Nath Mehta, Bhagat Singh's lawyer, went to meet him one last time a few hours before the time of his hanging on 23 March 1931, he was asked by the condemned man whether the urbane lawyer had brought him his book, *The Revolutionary Lenin*, and when Mr Mehta gave him the book, he set about reading it at once. He knew he had little time left in this world as a mortal man. The time of his hanging had been brought forward by eleven hours. As the fateful hour descended upon him in the twilight of the cool breezy evening, a fellow comrade of his, Manmathnath Gupta, recalls:

> When called upon to mount the scaffold, Bhagat Singh was reading a book by Lenin or on Lenin. He continued his reading and said, '*Wait a while. A revolutionary is talking to another revolutionary*.' There was something in his voice which made the executioners pause. Bhagat Singh continued to read. After a few moments, he flung the book towards [the] ceiling and said, '*Let's go*.'[16]

Small wonder that Ms Virendra Sindhu, Bhagat Singh's niece, has pointed out that another reason for Bhagat Singh's greatness lies in how '*Phansi par jhoolne se pahale, Bhagat Singh samaj ko ek naee vyavastha ka pura chitra pradaan kurna chahte the*'[17] ('Bhagat Singh succeeded in showing the world a new way of dying before mounting the gallows'). In fact, Juneja points out how, '[t]he supply of books by the Dwarka Das Library (Lahore) could not keep pace with his speed of reading. He requisitioned books so frequently that it was a problem for the jail authorities to scrutinize them'.[18] It is not implausible therefore that many of Bhagat Singh's friends should have thought that had he lived he would have become a university professor. Some have even argued that were a statue to be raised in his